

Why, Even in the 21st Century, Do People Still Like to Play with Nationalism?

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Nationalism is bound up with the nation-state. The nation-state is material superstructure; nationalism is ideology. As long as the nation-state exists, nationalism is bound to remain the dominant ideology.

In the stage of national industrial capitalism, the industrial system was embedded within each nation-state, so enterprises and nation-states were tightly bound together. If enterprises flourished, the nation-state prospered; a strong nation-state in turn created the conditions for enterprises to grow. Hence Hitler, in his speeches, could easily use nationalism to bind the fate of German industrial capital to the fate of the German worker, mobilising the masses into the ranks of fascism. Even in the socialist countries, industry was basically organised on the national level: any country with a certain scale of population and resources built itself an independent, self-reliant system — an independence even higher than that of ordinary capitalist nation-states. And because in the socialist countries enterprises could not arbitrarily lay off workers, and full employment was essentially achieved, nation, enterprise, and worker were even more highly unified. This, therefore, was the period when nationalism flourished most. Whether the nationalism of imperialist countries or the nationalism of oppressed nations, both had an extremely powerful appeal.

After the capitalist world-system entered its transnational production stage, the relationship between nation-states and enterprises became complicated. Large capitalist enterprises organise production across the globe, forming social relations with the governments and workers of many nation-states at once. The development of an enterprise no longer necessarily means the development of the nation-state associated with it; it may well mean the weakening of that nation-state. Hence Trump, in his speeches, denounces the big enterprises as creatures of pure profit that have shifted vast parts of material production abroad for their own gain, harming American workers, and argues that tariffs and similar measures must bring industry back to America. In this stage, the nation-state and the workers appear to be one, while the global flow of capital and the globalisation of production networks have made their relationship with the enterprise less certain.

In the age of globalisation, some non-nationalist ideologies, such as the "white left" current, have gradually grown stronger; but nationalism remains the dominant ideology, and the root of it lies in the identity of interests between the nation-state and the workers. That identity of interests is fundamentally caused by the fact that labour has not yet achieved free movement within the nation-

state; and as long as the nation-state remains the dominant form of state, the free global movement of labour will be very hard to achieve.

Three sets of reasons sustain the ordinary working masses' identification with nationalism:

First, the nation-state provides a whole set of social security institutions — pension insurance, medical insurance, and the like. The bourgeoisie and the upper middle class of senior experts and managers may not care much for such modest security. But to the ordinary worker and the petty-bourgeois toiler these guarantees are of vital importance: they decide whether one can maintain a basic livelihood in old age or upon losing the capacity to work. Hence, once a worker is tied to a nation-state and has worked and lived there for many years, changing nationality becomes unlikely.

At present, the EU countries have already achieved the accumulation of social insurance years across borders, precisely in order to build an all-European labour market. European opinion polls show^[1]: 74% of respondents believe that without the free movement of labour, the EU would not be worth having. In other words, the mutual recognition of social insurance is a key pillar of EU identity.

In fact, before China's provinces achieved the cross-province transfer and settlement of social insurance and medical insurance, the payment of insurance directly affected the free flow of labour across provinces. If social insurance remains different in each province, then as coverage gradually rises, Chinese workers' identification with their province or city may well come to exceed their identification with the country.

As long as the world has not unified into a single state, and countries have not achieved mutual recognition of social insurance, this factor will always have effect. The visible trend at present is that regional labour markets like the EU are giving rise to supranational identification. Mercosur, ASEAN, the East African Community, the Gulf Cooperation Council or some sort of Middle Eastern Muslim state league, and a possible future East Asian Community all have the potential to develop to this level.

Second, because levels of economic development differ greatly between regions of the world, and workers' living standards differ greatly between countries, there is a continuous one-way migration of labour from poorer countries to richer ones. In an age when unionisation rates are generally very low, the continuous inflow of poor-country labour inevitably sharpens the supply-demand contradiction in the labour market and harms the employment and incomes of native workers. Hence the workers of the rich countries need nationalism to influence the state apparatus and adopt anti-immigration policies, slowing or even stopping the influx. In this respect, the interests of the bourgeoisie conflict with the interests of the proletariat. But sometimes a part of the bourgeoisie — say, the real-estate bourgeoisie — may, for its own interests, ally with the working class against the mainstream bourgeoisie.

As the countries of the South gradually complete their industrialisation, the industrial advantages of the developed countries will be steadily eroded while the productive forces of the South rise substantially; the final result is the gradual levelling of real incomes of workers across the world. Countries with high per-capita incomes also have high living costs, and their workers' incomes, on a purchasing-power-parity basis, may be only 20% to 50% higher than those of workers in ordinary industrial countries. In such circumstances, workers will hardly migrate to another country just for such a wage difference. At the same time, because of job opportunities, marriage, culture, and other reasons, the movement of workers between countries will become multidirectional. In this respect, nationalism loses its foundation. This is similar to how the parochial regionalism of China's rich provinces will gradually become out of place — greatly weakened, even extinguished — as development spreads across the whole country.

Finally, in the current world-system, a country's economic standing depends on the position of its enterprises in the global value chains. In many cases, enterprises need the state to help them gain or maintain a dominant position in the industrial chain, and the state and the workers benefit from this too. But this community of interest requires a material condition: the state must provide the enterprises with a sufficient supply of highly skilled labour, which in turn requires maintaining a certain fertility rate and a good educational system. If the native working class cannot supply it, the needed labour must be brought in from across the globe — but this conflicts with the second point above.

Take the United States. Because its educational system is excessively marketised, it cannot train enough highly skilled talent from native students, so it must continuously attract immigrants from all over the world. But the continuing influx of immigrants deepens the nationalism of the native working class. And once that nationalism turns into anti-immigration policy, it is bound to harm the interests of native enterprises. If those enterprises do not shift their R&D and high-end manufacturing abroad, they will in the long run gradually lose their dominant position in the industrial chains. This contradiction is embodied in the MAGA camp's sharp conflict over the H-1B question between people like Musk and the deep-red MAGA of Bannon and others.

Thus both low fertility and the marketisation of education erode this structural pillar of nationalism. Precisely the countries that pursue "social-democratic" or "democratic-socialist" policies — lowering workers' cost of living, boosting fertility, strengthening public education — may be able to sustain the three-way relationship of enterprise, worker, and state. At present, democratic-socialist currents are spreading widely across the developed countries; although fiercely opposed by the establishment bourgeoisies, from the standpoint of the structural relationship between the world-system and the nation-state this reformist line can be accommodated by the existing nation-states. Yet social-democratic ideology is itself supranational: in many settings it pushes the workers of different

countries to unite against transnational capital, which in itself constitutes a dissolution of nationalism.

In sum, nationalism still has a deep material foundation in our time. But economic globalisation and political multipolarity will gradually change the structural division between North and South, and the low fertility in which all industrial countries are mired further weakens nationalism's material foundation. In the future, the final pillars of nationalism — apart from the indefinable "cultural" factor — will very likely be nothing more than the fact that welfare benefits such as social insurance cannot be mutually recognised across borders.

Notes

[1] "EU not worth having without free movement, say 74% of Europeans in Oxford survey": Some three quarters of Europeans say the European Union would "not be worth having" without freedom of movement, according to the latest highly-respected eupinions poll for the Oxford University Europe's Stories research project led by Professor Timothy Garton Ash. But the survey found strong support for the European Parliament, with four out of five supporting a supranational representative body.

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<https://www.ox.ac.uk/news/2021-01-26-eu-not-worth-having-without-free-movement-say-74-europeans-oxford-survey>

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